able to reverse himself. We have to let Kennedy know that we want to help him," Khrushchev told his minister of foreign affairs.[17]

Gromyko immediately instructed Dobrynin to contact Robert Kennedy. The message he forwarded to Washington read as follows: "The views expressed by Robert Kennedy at the president's request are met with understanding in Moscow. The reply to the president will be broadcast on radio today, and the reply will be most positive. The main problem troubling the president, that is, the dismantling of missile bases on Cuba under international supervision, arouses no objections and will be covered in detail in a message from N. S. Khrushchev."[18]

Khrushchev dictated a draft of his official letter to Kennedy to be edited and polished by his aides (Troianovsky later wrote that these were his colleagues from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) as soon as possible. "I respect and trust your statement, set forth in your message of October 27, 1962, that there will be no attack on Cuba; that there will be no invasion not only on the part of the United States but also on the part of other countries of the Western Hemisphere, as stated in your message," read the letter. "In that case, the motives that prompted us to provide such assistance to Cuba become invalid. We have therefore instructed our officers (and those resources, as I have already informed you, are in the hands of Soviet officers) to take appropriate measures to stop building the aforementioned installations, to dismantle them, and return them to the Soviet Union. As I have already informed you in my letter of October 27, we agree to arrange with you that UN representatives be able to verify the dismantling of those resources."[19]

That was it. Khrushchev accepted all Kennedy's conditions, including an immediate halt to the construction of new missile sites, the removal of the missiles, and UN supervision of their withdrawal. Robert Kennedy asked Dobrynin for a short and nonverbose answer. But Khrushchev would not have been Khrushchev if his letter were short and to the point. In a message of more than 1,500 words, he wrote at length on the peace-loving intentions of the Soviet people. Nor did he miss the opportunity to condemn unfriendly American actions: the shelling of Havana from an unidentified vessel and a U-2 flight over Soviet territory the previous day. "Your airplane violates our border, and at such an alarming time that we are